

MINECRAFT

Grade 7 Study Guide: Minecraft in the Media Literacy Classroom



**Teach
Media
Literacy
with games!**

CHAPTER CONTRIBUTED BY

Jan Lewis &
Jocelynn Mortlock

MINECRAFT

Grade 7 Study Guide: Minecraft in the Media Literacy Classroom

What's inside?

- Games in the Classroom - Rationale for Teachers
- Key Concepts & Focus Q's
- Lesson Building Blocks: Minecraft as a Media Text
- Minecraft P.I.E.
- Media Lit. Assignment for MC Education Edition



Introduction

Welcome to the world of Minecraft.

Minecraft Education Edition is an immersive open-world game that gives students the power of creativity to explore concepts in new, exciting ways! Like most games in a literacy classroom, Minecraft is highly motivating, encourages collaboration and creativity, and develops 21st Century skills of critical thinking and problem solving. Minecraft Media is great way to have students share their ideas and evaluate their understanding.

Join us as we build, block by block, concepts in Media Literacy using the computer game, Minecraft Education Edition.

Can We Really Use Minecraft to Teach Media Literacy?



“All the stuff that you know about literacy is true of digital media”
(James Paul Gee, 2012)

Minecraft Education Edition has been described by educators and players as an open "sandbox", where the informal, alternative learning environment allows students to draw upon knowledge and skills they might not have access to in a traditional classroom. Their level of participation and engagement is deeper (Brand & Kinash, 2013).



Minecraft is a tool that students can use to unlock new understandings about the world around them. With Minecraft, students are learning to view concepts through a lens from which they already relate. The activities are, therefore, more memorable and transferable beyond the virtual world. Minecraft, as a transmedia play, is "a new way to understand how children develop critical media literacy and new media literacies through their interactions with contemporary media [linking] stories and structures across platforms" (Alper & Herr-Stephensen, 2013).



Creative and Critical Thinking
Core Competency

Minecraft is more than a game!

It's collaborative!



Communication
Core Competency

In a classroom, it can be challenging enough to get students to work together towards an end goal. However, Minecraft provides opportunities for "negotiating, listening, following directions and accepting criticism" as they work their way together to complete tasks (Gallagher, 2015). Students will often talk amongst each other and other group members to find the most effective solution to a problem, or to help them overcome a challenge within a game. Students see the endless possibilities the game provides and want to arrive at the small success as quickly as possible to continue their feelings of success. Their collaboration skills are certain to develop with the incorporation of Minecraft.

It's engaging!

Ask any student who has played, Minecraft is fun! Educators who have tried it in the classroom can attest to the level of effectiveness in improving student motivation and engagement in their learning (Tromba, 2013). As students play, through trial and error of creative endeavours, their effort and practice is rewarded with "incremental goal progress" (Willis, 2011). Little successes lead to high motivation. In a Media Literacy classroom, Minecraft's creative immersion and open world means students can feel success constantly. Simply put, combining an immersive, engaging game with technology helps students grasp literacy concepts quicker!



Personal & Social
Core Competency

Key Concepts across the Curriculum

BC Curriculum – Grade 7

English Language Arts

- ▶ Think critically, creatively and reflectively to explore ideas within, between, and beyond texts
- ▶ Understand how literacy elements, techniques, and devices enhance and shape meaning
- ▶ Select and use appropriate features, forms and genres according to audience, purpose, and message

Arts Education

- ▶ Reflect on works of art and creative processes to understand artists' intentions
- ▶ Create artistic works collaboratively and as an individual using ideas inspired by imagination, inquiry, experimentation, and purposeful play

Ontario Curriculum – Grade 7

Media Literacy

- ▶ Demonstrate an understanding of a variety of media texts
- ▶ Identify some media forms and explain how the conventions and techniques associated with them are used to create meaning
- ▶ Create a variety of media texts for different purposes and audiences, using appropriate forms, conventions, and techniques
- ▶ Reflect on and identify their strengths as media interpreters and creators, areas for improvement, and the strategies they found most helpful in understanding and creating media texts

Focus Questions

Question 1: What are the similarities and differences between a print and a digital media form?

Question 2: What is the purpose of Minecraft as it relates to the "Purpose PIE" (persuade, inform, entertain)?

Question 3: What clues does the audience have in identifying the chosen purposes by the designers?

Question 4: What design elements and persuasion techniques would need to be included to convince your audience to choose your 'design' over another?

The following pages outline three lesson plans connected to the above Focus Questions. Curriculum assessment targets specific Ontario Media Literacy expectations which, as highlighted above, can easily fit within BC's generic Language Arts outcomes. Each lesson builds upon the previous one, requiring greater complexity of student thought and response.

Teachers should block out at least three periods for content presentation and several more once the culminating task has been assigned for student planning plus building time in-game, product presentations/Minecraft gallery walk, voting and evaluation of their chosen peer's media design.

Note: For schools without access to MCEE, this project can be completed using commercial MC or simply grid paper and product model building techniques, incorporating the square grid design to simulate Minecraft blocks.

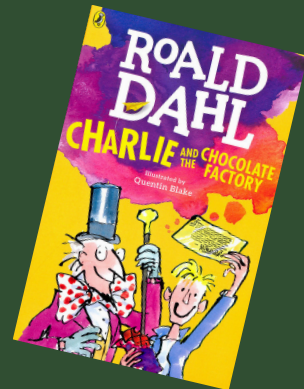
Distinguishing Between Print and Digital Media Types

In Lesson 1 Students Will...

2.1 explain how individual elements of various media forms combine to create, reinforce, and/or enhance meaning.

2.2 identify the conventions and techniques used in a variety of media forms and explain how they help convey meaning and influence or engage the audience.

1. Examine Roald Dahl's print book 'Charlie & The Chocolate Factory'



Guide students in identifying and describing the features of the book..

2. Create an anchor chart highlighting elements of print media. Draw out the fact that every media text is created by an author, with a purpose, for an audience to understand a message (overt) and also presents another (implied) message based on point of view.

3. Now, consider Minecraft (if possible project the game or a video of game play).

Have students:

- Decide what type of media Minecraft qualifies as. Share, with rationale.
- Explain how a video game such as Minecraft differs from print media.
- What similarities can be found? Define the term "digital" in this context.
- Add a Digital Media section to the anchor chart. Record the features discussed. Scaffold student understanding of features which are the same / different by deliberately printing them in two different colours
- Direct you in creating a shared Venn Diagram comparing print vs. digital media features.



Distinguishing Between Print and Digital Media Types

Name: _____ Date: _____

Venn Diagram

4. Students should now be ready to independently complete a Venn diagram, comparing and contrasting an example of a print media text of their choice (ie. a book, or a board game) with an example of digital media (ie. a video game, or a website).

Include a word bank of key media literacy elements for students to use:
(ie. contains similar format techniques)

Text	<i>Images</i>	Point of View	<i>Audience</i>
OVERT MESSAGE	<i>Colour</i>	Designer	Made for Viewer
<i>Implied message</i>	Author	Made for Player	

Assess using 2.1 and 2.2 above.

**PRINT OR DIGITAL MINECRAFT:
HOW MANY DIFFERENT MINECRAFT MEDIA TEXTS CAN YOU NAME?
INCLUDE BOTH PRINT AND DIGITAL TEXTS!**

made @ textcraft.net



Identifying the Purpose of Minecraft: Persuade, Inform, Entertain or "It Depends On..."?

In Lesson, 2 Students Will...

- 1.1 explain how various media texts address their intended purpose and audience.
- 1.2 interpret increasingly complex or difficult media texts, using overt and implied messages as evidence for their interpretations.

1. Introduce the three purposes of media texts, with relevant examples from both print and digital formats:

- **Persuade**... commercials, party invitations, speeches, movie trailers
- **Inform**... signage, documentaries, textbooks, learning games
- **Entertain**... films, video games, Snapchat, etc.

Students can create a collage in the shape of a pie sliced in thirds (or fourths if you'd like them to differentiate between "persuade" in general and "sell" as its own category of persuasion. If so, use the acronym P.I.E.S. instead) by drawing, printing or cutting and pasting their own examples of each of the media purposes.

2. In small groups, students must discuss and defend which piece of P.I.E.S. Minecraft fills. Have groups share their decision and rationale with the class. Pose examples of Minecraft texts that qualify for each of the four media purposes:

For example...

- * a YouTube video play-through comparing the new release version to an older version of Minecraft

Purpose P: to persuade the viewer to agree with the videographer's opinion of which version is superior

- * the tutorial world of MinecraftEdu

Purpose I: to inform new players how the controls work and how to interact with the game world



- * someone playing or watching someone else playing one week in Survival or Creative mode
- Purpose E: to entertain as the player has fun successfully solving challenges, which include eluding zombies and building things

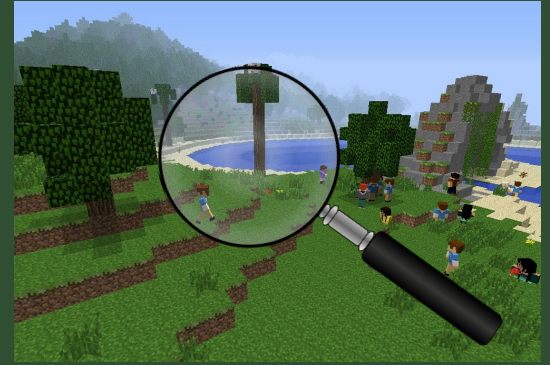
- * a trailer for the newest spin-off of Minecraft, such as Minecraft Story Mode
- Purpose S: to sell the product by showing off features the target audience will find desirable

Analyzing Minecraft P. I. E.

Be a detective!

3. Using the Think Aloud technique and visual aids, model how you can be a detective or solve a puzzle while viewing/experiencing a media text.

Begin by stating:



Literate consumers of media texts search for and notice clues within the media that they can use as evidence to determine the author, the audience, and the overt and implied messages.

Students should be made aware that media texts are designed on purpose and nothing is placed in a media text by accident. Therefore, clues can be put together to prove the underlying purpose of any media text.

Name:

Date:

Analyzing Minecraft P.I.E.S.

Example #1:

Watch the following Youtube video comparison of a newer and older version of Minecraft.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fVwhkdc34nQ>

What evidence can you find within this media type example?

How do these clues help determine who / what is:

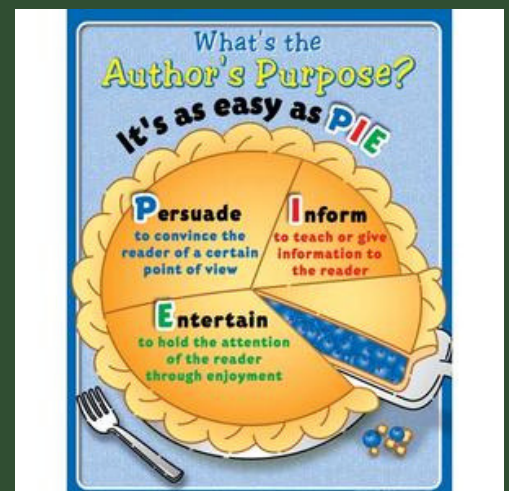
a) The Author?

b) The Audience?

c) The Overt message?

d) The Implied message?

What is the purpose of this media type? Explain.



4. Provide students with a sample of each of the Minecraft media purposes mentioned.

For each Minecraft media example, students must clearly explain how a media literate person would determine the purpose of such a text, even though this kind of digital media can be any piece of the P.I.E.S.

Assess using 1.1 and 1.2 above.

Mini-lessons and this Minecraft Media Task are inspired from the ideas found at the Roald Dahl Museum & built upon in the Charlie and the Chocolate Factory-inspired Minecraft Education Edition featured lesson page "Master's of Invention". This Media Guide can be used as a Media supplement. Original MCEE lesson plans can be downloaded from: <https://education.minecraft.net/lessons/masters-invention-roald-dahls-charlie-chocolate-factory/>

Creative Blocks of Candy

In Lesson 3 & the Final Task Students Will...

- 3.1 /3.2 identify an appropriate media form for a topic & explain how it suits the specific purpose and audience
- 3.3 identify conventions / techniques appropriate to their form of media text. Explain how conventions and techniques will be used to help communicate a message.
- 3.4 produce a variety of media texts for specific purposes and audiences, using appropriate forms, conventions, and techniques
- 1.3 evaluate the effectiveness of the presentation and treatment of ideas, information, themes, opinions, issues, and/or experiences in media texts



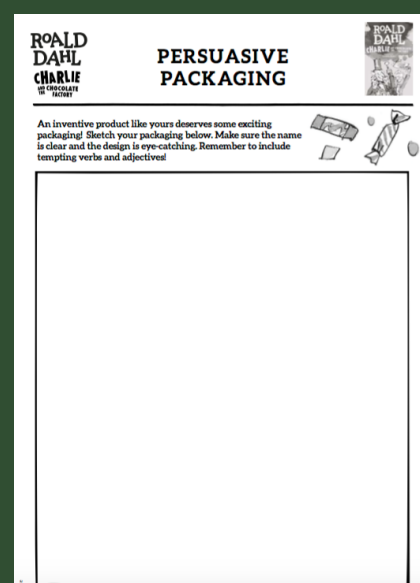
Through these expanded activities, students will demonstrate their grasp of the purpose of persuasion by engaging with a scenario in which they invent their own candy and pitch it to Charlie.

1. In pairs or small groups, students will complete mini-lessons, collaborate on paper plans, and present oral / video pitches before building their creation within an in-game MCEE gallery.
2. Finally, playing the role of Charlie, students will tour others' designs in-game and evaluate one of their peer's creations for its persuasive power. They will cast their vote for the winning candy and defend their choice using media terms. Assess using 3.1-3.4 & 1.3 above.

Teachers will need to adjust Minecraft-specific criteria to suit their school access and student experience. This page provides ideas and a possible framework for scheduling this rich, cumulative, multi-modal Media Literacy design challenge.

Final Task Materials Needed:

- Roald Dahl's Master's of Invention Lesson 2 p.9-15, including book Excerpt 1&2, and student copies of R1 Which Words Will WOW?, R2 Persuasive Packaging (on grid paper), and R3 Sweet Persuasion.
- Pencils, erasers, rulers, coloured pencils, grid paper.
- Evaluation response sheet (see Specific Expectation 1.3 above)
- Voting ballot and/or in-game/simulated "emerald" used to cast each student's vote as "Charlie"
- MinecraftEdu server & licenses enough for each child/group (<https://minecraftedu.com/purchase>)
- Whiteboard & projector (optional: for whole class gallery viewing or student presentations)



Print this candy/ package design using grid paper to help scale the idea into Minecraft blocks.

EXTENDING UNDERSTANDING

For students with Gifted designations/IEPs, or those who are very skilled in the Minecraft environment, the following Extension Activity, suggested on the MCEE lesson page, would be ideal.

Everything is Edible

"Most of us can never forget the moment from *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory* when the children enter the famous factory and discover the incredible chocolate room where everything is edible. As a formidable Minecraft player, your challenge is build a similar room and your imagine using only these blocks. Your room cannot be bigger than 10x10 blocks. We can't wait to see what you create!" (Minecraft Eduction, 2017).

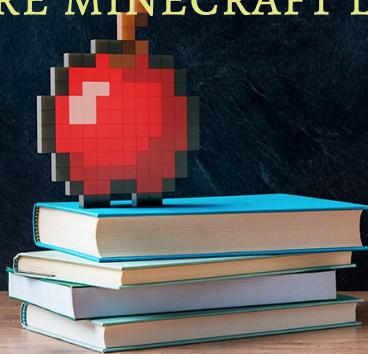


Create a "Let's Play" Using Minecraft Goals & Challenges

Minecraft Forum has posted a series of goals to extend the sense of challenge and success when playing solo. Invite students to create an additional media text in the form of a "Let's Play" video as they pursue the goals listed in this post.

MORE MINECRAFT LESSON PLANS

- More Minecraft & Media Literacy lessons
- Minecraft & Pinterest – MC-inspired activities
- Roald Dahl's 'James & the Giant Peach' Minecraft Lessons
- Minecraft STEM challenges – Improve MC Mastery with STEM



FURTHER READING

- Media Smarts - Parent & Teacher Guides to Video Game Use
- Common Sense Media - Minecraft Rating
- Minecraft in the Classroom teaches reading and more - article
- Getting Started with Minecraft - eBook
- Free Minecraft fiction for kids - downloads for Kindle

PHOTO CREDITS

Amazing Minecraft House. Hl'adat' Googlom. Retrieved from: <http://nationalshomeplate.com/detail/0267fbfd-minecraft-house-goes-underground-hladat-googlom-minecraft.html>

Apple-1920. Minecraft Education Edition - Mojang. Retrieved from: <https://education.minecraft.net/>

BC Curriculum Triangle - 1. WellAhead Ideas. Retrieved from: <http://prototypes.wellahead.ca/wp-content/uploads/2016/05/BC-Curriculum-Triangles-01.png>

BC Curriculum Triangle - 2. WellAhead Ideas. Retrieved from: <http://prototypes.wellahead.ca/wp-content/uploads/2016/05/BC-Curriculum-Triangles-02.png>

BC Curriculum Triangle - 3. WellAhead Ideas. Retrieved from: <http://prototypes.wellahead.ca/wp-content/uploads/2016/05/BC-Curriculum-Triangles-03.png>

Candy House MC. Mncrftpcs. Retrieved from: <http://mncrftpcs.com/2012/01/02/candy+house+minecraft>

Charlie and the Chocolate Factory. Vernon Barford School. Licensed under CC-BY-NC-ND-2.0. Retrieved from: <https://www.flickr.com/photos/vernonbarford/34224495813>

Keep Calm and Read On. Phorest. Retrieved from: <https://phorest.org/minecraft-poster-minecraft-print-minecraft-wall-art-minecraft-art-minecraft-decor/>

Magnifying Glass. Pixabay. Licensed under CC0 Creative Commons. Retrieved from: <https://pixabay.com/en/magnifying-glass-magnify-glass-1293096/>

Minecraft Block. David Charles Bitterbaum. Retrieved from: <http://www.thenewstrant.com/2017/10/i-attempted-to-read-two-graphic-novels.html>

Minecraft Building Block Cube Pixel. Pixabay. Licensed under Creative Commons CC0. Retrieved from: <https://pixabay.com/en/minecraft-building-block-block-cube-154749/>

Minecraft Emerald. Kara's Party Ideas. Retrieved from: <http://karaspartyideas.com/2013/12/awesome-minecraft-themed-birthday-party.html/mine>

Minecraft Horse. Minecraft Softonic. Retrieved from: <https://minecraft.en.softonic.com/mac>

Minecraft Jams. Screenshot from: <https://gaming.youtube.com/watch?v=QESGFbc1UZM&feature=share>

Minecraft Logo. FreePNG Logos. Retrieved from: <http://www.freepnglogos.com/logos/minecraft-logo>

Minecraft Novel & Non-Fiction Book Covers. Minecraft Madness - Mercer County Library Blog. Retrieved from: <http://mercercountylibrary.blogspot.ca/2016/01/minecraft-madness.html>

Minecraft Overlooking Lake. Minecraft.net. Retrieved from: <https://minecraft.net/en-us/>

Minecraft snapshot 13w22a. Dinnerbone - Mojang. Retrieved from: <https://mojang.com/2013/05/minecraft-snapshot-13w22a/>

Minecraft Storymode Stacy and Stampy. Stacy Plays. Retrieved from: http://stacyplays.wikia.com/wiki/My_Storymode_House

Notepad. Herbert88. Licensed under CC0 Creative Commons. Retrieved from: <https://pixabay.com/en/notepad-note-memo-paper-stickies-2154581/>

Purpose P.I.E. Really Good Stuff. Retrieved from: <http://jeanporter.cmswiki.wikispaces.net/AUTHOR%27S+PURPOSE>

Venn Diagram. More Time 2 Teach. Retrieved from: <https://www.teacherspayteachers.com/FreeDownload/FREEBIE-Venn-Diagram-wlines-908461>

- Alper, M., & Herr-Stephenson, R. (2013). Transmedia play: Literacy across media. *Journal of Media Literacy Education*, 5(2), 366-369.
- Baddeley, Simon. (18 Oct. 2016). Immersive Engagement in Minecraft: Education Edition. Minecraft Developer. Retrieved from: <https://blogs.msdn.microsoft.com/austeachers/2016/08/10/minecraft-and-the-power-of-immersive-engagement/>
- Brand, J., & Kinash, S. (2013). Crafting minds in Minecraft.
- Building Student Success - BC's New Curriculum. (2017). Government of British Columbia. Retrieved from: <https://curriculum.gov.bc.ca/curriculum-updates>
- Dini, K., Jacobs, T. (2009). The Good Things About Video Games. Media Smarts: Canada's Centre for Digital and Media Literacy. Retrieved from: <http://mediasmarts.ca/video-games/good-things-about-video-games>
- Ellison, T. L., & Evans, J. N. (2016). Minecraft, teachers, parents, and learning: What they need to know and understand. *School Community Journal*, 26(2), 25.
- Gallagher, Colin, et al. (2015). *Minecraft in the Classroom: Ideas, inspiration, and student projects for teachers*. Peachpit Press: Pearson Education.
- Minecraft Education. (7 June, 2017). Masters of Invention: Roald Dahl's Charlie and the Chocolate Factory. Minecraft Education Edition. Retrieved from: <https://education.minecraft.net/lessons/masters-invention-roald-dahls-charlie-chocolate-factory/>
- O'Connell, Beth. (2 Oct. 2017). VSTE Voices: Minecraft and Media Literacy. Virginia Society for Technology in Education. Retrieved from: <https://vste.org/vste-voices-minecraft-and-media-literacy/>
- Ontario Curriculum: Elementary. (2006). Ontario Ministry of Education. Retrieved from: <http://www.edu.gov.on.ca/eng/curriculum/elementary/language18currb.pdf>
- Overby, A., & Jones, B. L. (2015). Virtual LEGOs: Incorporating Minecraft into the art education curriculum. *Art Education*, 68(1), 21-27.
- Selwyn, N., & Stirling, E. (2016). Social media and education... now the dust has settled. *Learning, Media and Technology*, 41(1), 1-5.
- Tromba, P. (2013). Building engagement and knowledge one block at a time with Minecraft. *ISTE Leading and Learning with Technology*. Retrieved from: <http://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/EJ1015174.pdf>
- Willis, Judy. (14 Apr. 2011) A Neurologist Makes the Case for the Video Game Model as a Learning Tool. Edutopia. Retrieved from: <https://www.edutopia.org/blog/neurologist-makes-case-video-game-model-learning-tool>